A Project Report on

A Study on the Entrepreneurial Ecosystem of Kunnamkulam Municipality of Thrissur

Submitted by

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Chapter 1: Introduction

Entrepreneurship has long been recognised as a vital engine of local economic development, capable of transforming urban spaces into dynamic hubs of innovation, employment, and social mobility. Within the decentralised governance framework of Kerala — a state celebrated for its distinctive "Kerala Model" of high human development alongside participatory local self-government — the role of the municipality as a facilitator of entrepreneurial activity has assumed growing significance. It is within this broader context that Kunnamkulam emerges as a compelling case study of grassroots entrepreneurial vitality embedded in a historically rich commercial landscape.

Kunnamkulam is a municipal town located in the Thrissur District of Kerala, with historical origins tracing back to the Paleolithic age. Its strategic location and excellent connectivity make it an important economic and cultural node, linking the southern regions of Kerala with North Malabar and serving as a crucial point for travel and trade. The town has remote antiquity, having once been part of Mahodayapattanam, the capital of the Chera Dynasty, and during the Sangam period, the area engaged in active trade with the Roman Empire and other civilisations of the time. This deep-rooted tradition of commerce and exchange forms the historical bedrock upon which Kunnamkulam's contemporary entrepreneurial culture rests. Kunnamkulam’s geographical position has significantly contributed to its entrepreneurial growth. Located along major road networks connecting Central Kerala with Malabar regions, the municipality enjoys easy accessibility for transportation, trade, and mobility of labour. Its proximity to important commercial centres such as Guruvayur, Thrissur, and Chavakkad has encouraged continuous market interaction and customer flow. The region’s semi-urban character also enables enterprises to access both rural production networks and urban consumer markets, creating favourable conditions for small-scale industries, retail trade, and service-sector expansion.

The city is well-known for its printing and bookbinding industries, which have been a part of its economy for many years, and today has a population of approximately 54,636. Kunnamkulam has also played a significant role in the spice trade and served as a centre for traditional crafts, while emerging as a prominent educational hub within Thrissur district. Its proximity to the pilgrimage centre of Guruvayur and the coastal town of Chavakkad further amplifies its commercial relevance, attracting diverse flows of people, goods, and capital into its markets. Established in 1948 as a Grade-IV municipality, Kunnamkulam has evolved significantly, being upgraded in 2000 through the amalgamation of the Arthat panchayat and parts of Porkulam and Chowwannur panchayats, expanding its area to 34.18 sq. km and encompassing 39 electoral wards.

In recent years, Kunnamkulam Municipality has demonstrated a proactive approach to governance and sustainability. In 2022, Kunnamkulam embarked on a mission to achieve carbon-neutral status by 2030, and in 2020 it launched an effort to become Thrissur District's first hunger-free town under Kerala's Subhiksha Project. These initiatives reflect a municipality that is not merely reactive but is actively shaping its developmental trajectory — a quality that is inseparable from its entrepreneurial ambitions. The entrepreneurial culture of

Kunnamkulam is also deeply influenced by its social and cultural composition, particularly the contribution of traditional business communities such as the Christian families. Historically known for their involvement in trade, finance, printing, and commercial activities, these families helped cultivate a strong business-oriented mindset within the town. Their legacy of risk-taking, family-based enterprise management, and intergenerational transfer of commercial knowledge continues to shape the entrepreneurial environment of Kunnamkulam even today.

The present study, conducted under the KILA School of Urban Governance in collaboration with Kunnamkulam Municipality, seeks to examine the entrepreneurial ecosystem of this historically significant town through the lens of three institutional pillars: the Cognitive Pillar (shared vocational knowledge and skills), the Normative Pillar (the cultural value of risk-taking and enterprise), and the Regulatory Pillar (governmental and municipal support structures). Drawing on primary field survey data collected across all 39 wards of the municipality from entrepreneurs engaged in diverse sectors — spanning manufacturing, trading, services, and social enterprise — this report analyses patterns in business formation, access to finance, market reach, technology adoption, institutional support, and resilience. The survey also documents the voices of entrepreneurs on governance, sustainability, and their aspirations for the future. In addition, the study is organised around seven thematic frameworks that examine different dimensions of the entrepreneurial ecosystem: demographic profile of entrepreneurs, enterprise characteristics, finance and credit access, market reach and business growth, technology adoption, sustainability practices, governance and institutional support, social inclusion and gender participation, and future aspirations and resilience of enterprises.

The insights generated through this study are intended to contribute to evidence-based policy recommendations that can strengthen Kunnamkulam as an inclusive, resilient, and sustainable entrepreneurial city — one that not only builds on its rich commercial heritage but charts a forward-looking path within Kerala's decentralised development framework. Kunnamkulam is considered an ideal entrepreneurial city because of its strong trading culture, active small and medium enterprises, supportive business environment, and ability to create employment and economic growth, making it a model for other regions to follow.

Methodology:-

The study adopted a quantitative descriptive and analytical research design to examine the entrepreneurial ecosystem of Kunnamkulam Municipality. The research was mainly based on secondary data collected from municipal records, government reports, institutional publications, and compiled datasets. In addition, primary information was collected using a structured questionnaire administered to entrepreneurs across different sectors.

The collected data were coded, classified, and analysed using Microsoft Excel and R Statistical Software. Excel was used for data tabulation, percentage analysis, charts, and descriptive statistics, while R was used for hypothesis testing and inferential statistical analysis.

The statistical tools used in the study include:

- Percentage and frequency analysis
- Chi-square test
- Fisher's Exact Test
- Spearman Rank Correlation
- Kruskal–Wallis Test

The hypotheses were tested at a 5% level of significance to identify relationships and differences among entrepreneurial variables.

Limitations:-

- A large number of "Not Applicable (NA)" responses reduced the effective sample size for several analyses.
- Some respondents did not disclose demographic information, limiting subgroup-based interpretation.
- Several variables were categorical and ordinal, restricting the use of advanced parametric statistical methods.
- Many enterprises lacked formal financial records, affecting the precision of turnover and investment-related responses.
- Open-ended qualitative responses could not be fully converted into measurable quantitative variables.
- Some statistical tests contained low expected frequencies, requiring alternative testing procedures such as Fisher's Exact Test.
- The study was cross-sectional and therefore cannot establish long-term causal relationships.
- Technology adoption and business modernisation were measured using limited indicators and may not fully capture broader entrepreneurial transformation.
- Since the research was limited to Kunnamkulam Municipality, the findings may not be fully generalizable to other regions.

Chapter 2: Statistical Analysis

2.1 Socio-economic Profile of Respondents

TABLE 1:- Distribution of Entrepreneurs by sex

sex	Count of Sex	% sex
Female	151	30.94%
Male	337	69.06%
Grand Total	488	100.00%

Source: Primary Data

Note: The Table 1 presents the gender-wise classification of respondents and helps to understand the demographic composition of entrepreneurs included in the survey. A total of 489 responses were received in the survey.

Inference:

The survey shows a clear gender gap among the respondents. Male entrepreneurs make up 69.06% of the respondents, while female entrepreneurs account for 30.94%. This indicates that the participation of male entrepreneurs is higher than that of female entrepreneurs. Among which one respondent preferred not to disclose their gender.

TABLE 2:-Education level of Entrepreneurs

Education level	percentage	Count
BELOW SSLC	13.42%	62
DIPLOMA	6.49%	30
GRADUATION	18.61%	86
PhD	0.22%	1
PLUS TWO	17.97%	83
POST GRADUATION	4.98%	23
PROFESSIONAL QUALIFICATION	2.81%	13
SSLC	35.50%	164
Grand Total	100.00%	462

Source: Primary Data

Note: The Table 2 presents the education-wise classification of entrepreneurs and helps to understand the educational background of the respondents. A total of 489 responses were received in the survey, out of which 27 responses were marked as “Not Applicable”

Inference:

The results indicate that most entrepreneurs have SSLC education (35.50%).Only 0.22% of respondents has a PhD, showing that very few belong to this category. This indicates that entrepreneurship participation is more common among respondents with general educational backgrounds.

TABLE 3:-Distribution of Survey Respondents by Social Category

Category	Count of Social Category	Percentage
Do not wish to disclose	209	42.74%
OBC	161	32.92%
Other	91	18.61%
SC	27	5.52%
ST	1	0.20%
Grand Total	489	100.00%

Source: Primary Data

Note: The Table 3 presents the social category-wise distribution of respondents included in the study and provides an overview of the social background of the entrepreneurs surveyed. Out of the total 489 respondents surveyed, all responses were considered for analysis.

Inference:

Many respondents preferred not to reveal their social category. Among those who disclosed it, the majority belong to the OBC category, while only a few respondents belong to SC and ST categories.

TABLE 4:-Type of Enterprise

Type of Enterprise	Count of Type of enterprise	Type of enterprise%
Animal husbandry	14	2.90%
Cultural/Entertainment Industry	18	3.73%
Manufacturing / Production	140	29.05%
Mixed (manufacturing + trading)	16	3.32%
Processing	19	3.94%
Service	140	29.05%
Social Entrepreneurship	11	2.28%
Trading	124	25.73%
Grand Total	482	100.00%

Source: Primary Data

Note: The Table 4 presents the classification of respondents based on the type of enterprise and helps to understand the nature of businesses among entrepreneurs. A total of 489 responses were received in the survey, out of which 7 responses were marked as Not Applicable.

Inference:

Trading businesses are more related to market activities. Manufacturing businesses show production strength. Service Business reflects modern economic development.

TABLE 5:- Capital Investment

Capital Investment	Count	PERCENTAGE
1 Crore - 10 Crore	6	1.62%
10 Lack - 1 Crore	32	8.65%
1-10 Lack	162	43.78%
Less than 1 Lack	168	45.41%
More than 10 Crore	2	0.54%
Grand Total	370	100.00%

Source: Primary Data

Note: The table 5 presents the classification of respondents based on capital investment and helps to understand the investment pattern among entrepreneurs. A total of 489 responses were received in the survey, out of which 119 responses were marked as Not Applicable.

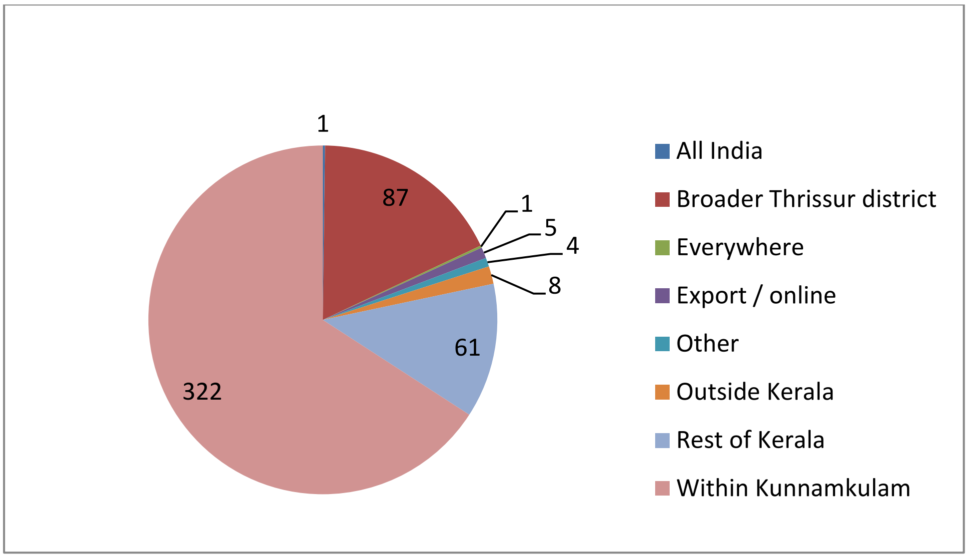
Inference:

The Business with low capital mainly belongs to small scale enterprises. High capital business show better investment strength.

TABLE 6:- Market Reach and Business Growth

Market	Count	Percentage
All India	1	0.20%
Broader Thrissur district	87	17.79%
Everywhere	1	0.20%
Export / online	5	1.02%
Other	4	0.82%
Outside Kerala	8	1.64%
Rest of Kerala	61	12.47%
Within Kunnamkulam	322	65.85%
Grand Total	489	100.00%

Source: Primary Data



Note: The Table 6 and graph presents the classification of respondents based on market reach and business growth and helps to understand the market coverage of entrepreneurs. A total of 489 responses were received in the survey and all responses were considered for analysis.

Inference:

The most businesses mainly depend on markets within Kunnamkulam.

TABLE 7:-Business Expansion

Business Expansion	Count	Percentage
Expanded	161	32.92%
Shrunk	126	25.77%
Stayed the same	202	41.31%
Grand Total	489	100.00%

Source: Primary Data

Note: The Table 7 presents the classification of respondents based on business expansion and helps to understand the growth status of enterprises. A total of 489 responses were received in the survey and all responses were considered for analysis.

Inference:

The Business continued at the same level without major growth or decline.

TABLE 8:-Source of Capital and Financial Inclusion

Source of Capital	Count	Count of Primary source of capital when you started or last expanded:
Commercial bank	79	21.07%
Cooperative bank	30	8.00%
Government scheme	18	4.80%
Informal moneylender	11	2.93%
Microfinance / Kudumbashree	17	4.53%
Other	12	3.20%
Personal / family savings	207	55.20%
Personal savings and loans	1	0.27%
Grand Total	375	100.00%

Source: Primary Data

Note: The Table 8 presents the different sources of capital used by entrepreneurs for starting or expanding their businesses and reflects the level of financial inclusion among the respondents. Out of the total 489 respondents surveyed, 114 respondents were marked as not applicable for this question.

Inference:

The most entrepreneurs mainly depend on personal or family savings for business capital.

TABLE 9: Government scheme application status by social categories

Government scheme application status	SC	ST	OBC	Other	Do not wish to disclose	NA	Grand Total
Yes-received benefit	1		26	14	19	9	69
Yes- application rejected	2		5	3	4		14
Applied still pending			2	4	2	5	13
Never Applied	18		101	44	84	40	287
NA	6	1	27	26	18	28	106
Grand Total	27	1	161	91	127	82	489

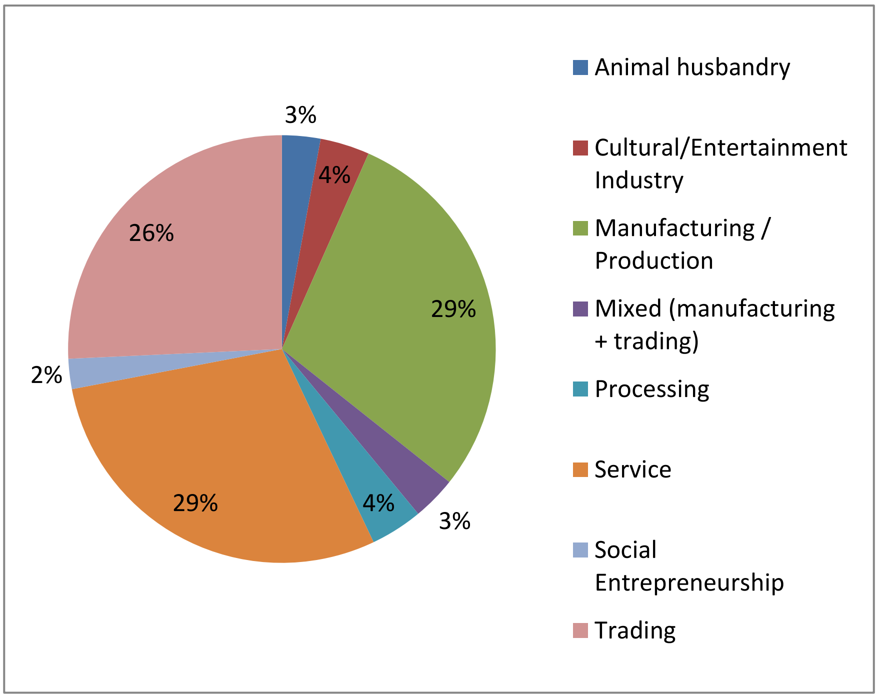
Source: Primary Data

Note: This table 9 studies the relationship between social categories and government scheme application status. There were 27 respondents marked as "NA" in the social category and 13 respondents marked as "NA" in government scheme application status, which may affect the accuracy of the analysis.

Inference:

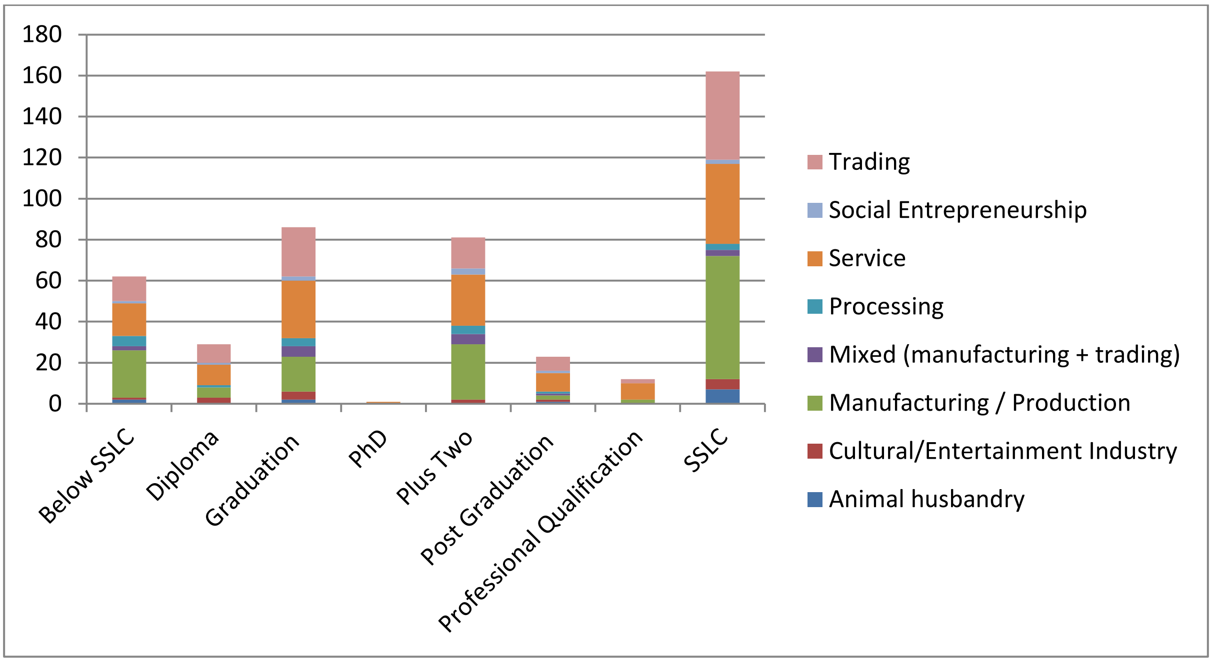
The table shows that most respondents from all social categories never applied for government schemes. Only a small number received benefits, while very few applications were rejected or are still pending. OBC respondents and those who did not wish to disclose their category showed comparatively higher participation in government scheme

2.1 Sectorial Distribution of Enterprises by Number of Women Employees



The pie chart shows that the highest number of women employees is working in the manufacturing/production and service sectors. Trading businesses also employ a considerable number of women. On the other hand, sectors like animal husbandry and social entrepreneurship have very few women employees. This indicates that women are mainly employed in production, service, and trading-related activities. There were 114 participants marked as not applicable in the data.

2.2 Sectorial Distribution of Enterprises by Education Qualification of Employees



The chart shows that most enterprises are run by entrepreneurs with SSLC, Plus Two, and Graduation qualifications. Manufacturing/production, service, and trading sectors have the highest number of enterprises. Graduates are more involved in service and trading activities, while SSLC-qualified entrepreneurs are mainly involved in manufacturing/production.
Very few entrepreneurs have PhD or professional qualifications.

2.3 Access to Credit and Business Growth

OBJECTIVE: To examine whether ease of accessing credit affects enterprise growth

H0: There is no significant relationship between ease of accessing credit and enterprise growth.
H1: There is a significant relationship between ease of accessing credit and enterprise growth.

RESULT:

Spearman's rho (ρ)	-0.224
S(Test statistic)	12,764,273
p-value	6.596×10^{-6}
Level of significance	0.05

INTERPRETATION:

Spearman rank correlation analysis was conducted to examine the relationship between ease of accessing credit and enterprise growth. The results revealed a statistically significant weak correlation between the variables (ρ=−0.224\rho = -0.224ρ=−0.224, p<0.05). the negative coefficient suggests that enterprises with easier access to credit tend to experience better market growth and expansion.

Here the p-value is less than 0.05, therefore we reject the null hypothesis .There is a significant relationship between ease of accessing credit and enterprise growth.

2.4 Government Scheme Application and Enterprise Expansion

OBJECTIVE: To Examine Whether enterprises that applied for government schemes experienced better growth.

H0: There is no significant association between applying for government schemes and enterprise growth.
H1: There is a significant association between applying for government schemes and enterprise growth.

RESULT:

Pearson's Chi-squared test

Data	Table data
X-squared	7.0657
df	6
p-value	0.3148

INTERPRETATION:

A Chi-square test of association was conducted to examine the relationship between applying for government schemes and enterprise growth. The analysis revealed no statistically significant association between the variables (chi^2(6) = 7.066, p=0.315). Therefore, the null hypothesis was not rejected. This suggests that applying for government schemes was not significantly associated with enterprise growth among the surveyed enterprises.

Here the p-value is greater than 0.05, therefore fail to reject the null hypothesis. This indicates that the growth status of enterprises (expanded, stayed the same, or shrunk) does not significantly differ based on the type of response regarding government scheme application

2.5 Support from municipal officials And Business convenience

OBJECTIVE: To examine whether Support from municipal officials influences business convenience in Kunnamkulam.

H0: There is no significant relationship between Support from municipal officials and business convenience.
H1: There is a significant relationship between Support from municipal officials and business convenience.

RESULT:

Pearson's Chi-squared test

Data	
X-squared	71.39
df	12
p-value	1.758e-10

Fisher's Exact Test for Count Data with simulated p-value (based on 2000 replicates)

Data	
p-value	0.0004998
Alternative hypoth esis	Two sided

INTERPRETATION:

A Chi-square test of association was conducted to examine the relationship between municipal interaction and business convenience. The analysis revealed a statistically significant association between the variables ($\chi^2 = 71.39$, df = 12, $p < 0.001$). Since some expected frequencies were low, Fisher's Exact Test with simulated p-values was also performed, which confirmed the significance of the relationship ($p < 0.001$).

Here the p-value is less than 0.05, therefore the null hypothesis was rejected, and indicating that municipal interaction significantly influences business convenience among enterprises in Kunnamkulam. The way the municipality interacts with businesses significantly affects the ease of doing business.

2.6 Women Employment and Enterprise Type

OBJECTIVE: Whether certain enterprise types employ more women

H0: There is no significant difference in women employment across enterprise types.
H1: There is a significant difference in women employment across enterprise types.

RESULT:

Pearson's Chi-squared test

Data	
X-squared	24.186
df	14
p-value	0.04351

Fisher's Exact Test for Count Data with simulated p-value (based on 2000 replicates)

Data	
p-value	0.03498
Alternative hypothesis	Two sided

INTERPRETATION:

A Chi-square test of association was conducted to examine the relationship between enterprise type and women employment. The analysis revealed a statistically significant association between the variables (chi^2(14) = 24.186, p = 0.043). Therefore, the null hypothesis was rejected. This suggests that women employment significantly differs across different types of enterprises among the surveyed enterprises.

Here the p-value is less than 0.05; therefore we reject the null hypothesis. This indicates that certain enterprise types employ comparatively more women than others. Since some expected cell frequencies were small, Fisher's Exact Test with simulated p-values was also conducted. The Fisher's test result (p=0.035) further confirmed the existence of a statistically significant association between enterprise type and women employment.

2.7 Turnover and Market Reach

OBJECTIVE: Whether certain enterprise types employ more women

H0: There is no significant relationship between turnover and market reach.
H1: There is a significant relationship between turnover and market reach.

RESULT:

Spearman's rank correlation rho

Data	
S	2052772
p-value	0.8526
Alternative hypothesis:	True rho is not 0
Sample estimates, rho	-0.01231736

INTERPRETATION:

A Spearman rank correlation test was conducted to examine the relationship between turnover and market reach among enterprises. The analysis revealed the correlation coefficient was very weak and negative (rho = -0.012), indicating almost no relationship between turnover and market reach

Here the p-value is greater than 0.05, therefore the null hypothesis was not rejected. This suggests that turnover is not significantly associated with market reach among the surveyed enterprises that is enterprises with higher turnover do not necessarily experience greater market expansion compared to enterprises with lower turnover

2.8 Technology Usage and Market Expansion

OBJECTIVE: To examine whether enterprises using modern technology achieve wider market expansion

H0: There is no significant association between technology usage and market expansion among enterprises.
H1: There is a significant association between technology usage and market expansion among enterprises.

RESULT:

Pearson's Chi-squared test

data	
X-squared	52.176
Df	62
p-value	0.8086

Fisher's Exact Test for Count Data with simulated p-value (based on 2000 replicates)

Data	
p-value	0.8456
Alternative hypothesis	Two sided

INTERPRETATION:

A Chi-square test of association was conducted to examine the relationship between technology usage and market expansion among enterprises. The analysis revealed no statistically significant association between the variables (chi^2(62)=52.176, p=0.809) Since some expected cell frequencies were small, Fisher's Exact Test with simulated p-values was also conducted. The Fisher's test result (p=0.846) further confirmed that there is no statistically significant association between technology usage and market expansion

Here the p-value is greater than 0.05 therefore, the null hypothesis was not rejected. This suggests that technology usage is not significantly associated with market expansion among the surveyed enterprises that is the level or type of technology adoption does not significantly differ with the market expansion status of enterprises.

2.9 Age and Business Modernization

OBJECTIVE: To examine whether the age of the entrepreneur affects the level of business modernization.

H0: There is no significant difference in the level of business modernisation across different age groups of entrepreneurs.
H1: There is a significant difference in the level of business modernisation across different age groups of entrepreneurs.

RESULT:

Kruskal-Wallis rank sum test

Data	
Kruskal-Wallis chi-squared	34.85
df	13
p-value	0.0008927

Here we create a "Modernisation Score" convert the multiple responses into a count score

- 0 = no modernisation
- 1 = adopted 1 method
- 2 = adopted 2 methods
- 3 = adopted 3 methods

This becomes an ordinal/discrete numeric variable and compares Modernisation Score across Age Groups

INTERPRETATION:

A Kruskal–Wallis test was conducted to examine the difference in the level of business modernisation across different age groups of entrepreneurs. The analysis revealed a statistically significant difference between age groups and business modernisation (\chi^2 = 34.85, p = 0.0008927)

Since the p-value is less than 0.05, the null hypothesis was rejected. This suggests that the level of business modernisation significantly varies among different age groups of entrepreneurs. This indicates that entrepreneurs belonging to different age groups differ significantly in their adoption of modern business practices and modernisation strategies.

2.10 Trade Bodies and Political Participation

OBJECTIVE: To examine the role of trade bodies in connecting entrepreneurs with governance institutions

H0: There is no significant association between trade body support and entrepreneurs' perception that their voices reach municipal decision-makers.
H1: There is a significant association between trade body support and entrepreneurs' perception that their voices reach municipal decision-makers.

RESULT:

Fisher's Exact Test for Count Data

Data	
p-value	0.531
Alternative hypothesis	Two sided

INTERPRETATION:

Fisher's Exact Test was conducted to examine the association between trade body support and entrepreneurs' perception of governance connectivity in Kunnamkulam.

The test produced a p-value of 0.531, which is greater than the significance level of 0.05.
Therefore, the null hypothesis was not rejected. This indicates that there is no statistically significant association between receiving support from trade bodies and the perception that entrepreneurs' voices reach municipal decision-makers that is entrepreneurs who benefit from trade bodies do not significantly differ in their perception of governance connectivity compared to those who do not receive such support.

2.11 Proximity Advantage and Entrepreneurial Growth

OBJECTIVE: To examine whether proximity to Chavakkad and Guruvayur is associated with business growth/market reach.

H0: There is no significant relationship between proximity to Chavakkad and Guruvayur and business growth/market reach.

H1: There is a significant relationship between proximity to Chavakkad and Guruvayur and business growth/market reach.

RESULT:

Spearman's rho (ρ)	-0.046
S	15,159,122
p-value	0.332
Level of significance	0.05

INTERPRETATION:

A Spearman's Rank Correlation test was conducted to examine the relationship between proximity to Chavakkad and Guruvayur and the change in market reach of businesses over the past five years. The results showed a very weak negative correlation between the variables ($\rho = -0.046$). However, the relationship was not statistically significant ($p = 0.332$), as the p-value is greater than the 0.05 level of significance.

Since the p-value is greater than 0.05, the null hypothesis is accepted. Therefore, there is no statistically significant relationship between proximity to Chavakkad and Guruvayur and business market reach growth over the past five years. This indicates that proximity to Chavakkad and Guruvayur does not have a significant influence on the market reach growth of businesses in the study area.

Chapter 3: Findings of the study

Major findings

- Male entrepreneurs dominate the entrepreneurial ecosystem.
- Most entrepreneurs possess SSLC-level education.
- Manufacturing, service, and trading sectors dominate the local economy.
- Most enterprises operate with low capital investment below ₹10 lakh.
- Most businesses mainly depend on markets within Kunnamkulam.
- Most enterprises remained stable without major growth or decline.
- Personal and family savings are the major source of business capital.
- Male participation in entrepreneurship is comparatively higher.
- Most entrepreneurs never applied for government schemes.
- Women employees are mainly concentrated in manufacturing, service, and trading sectors.
- Entrepreneurs with SSLC, Plus Two, and Graduation qualifications dominate most sectors.
- Access to credit significantly influences enterprise growth.
- Government scheme application does not significantly influence enterprise growth.
- Support from Municipal officials significantly affects business convenience.
- Women employment significantly differs across enterprise types.
- Turnover does not significantly influence market reach.
- Technology usage does not significantly affect market expansion.
- Business modernisation significantly varies across age groups.
- Trade body support does not significantly affect governance connectivity perception.
- Proximity to Guruvayur and Chavakkad does not significantly influence business growth.

Recommendations

- The study recommends strengthening institutional and financial support systems for entrepreneurs in Kunnamkulam by improving access to affordable credit, simplifying loan procedures, and increasing awareness about government schemes and financial assistance programs.
- The municipality should improve entrepreneur–government interaction through better complaint resolution mechanisms, business facilitation centres, and simplified administrative procedures to enhance business convenience and governance support.
- The study further recommends promoting women entrepreneurship and employment through targeted training, financial assistance, and skill development programs, especially in manufacturing, trading, and service sectors where women participation is comparatively higher.

- Special attention should also be given to youth entrepreneurship and skill-oriented enterprise development to encourage innovation and modern business practices among younger entrepreneurs.
- In addition, greater focus should be given to business modernisation, digital adoption, e-commerce, online marketing, and technology-based management systems to improve long-term sustainability and competitiveness.
- Entrepreneurs should be encouraged to expand their market reach beyond local markets through branding initiatives, trade fairs, networking opportunities, and external business linkages.
- The study also suggests strengthening coordination between municipal institutions, trade bodies, financial institutions, educational institutions, and entrepreneurs to create a more inclusive and growth-oriented entrepreneurial ecosystem.
- Improving entrepreneurial awareness, financial literacy, and sustainability practices can further support the transformation of Kunnamkulam into a stronger and more modern entrepreneurial municipality.

Conclusions

The study on Kunnamkulam highlights the presence of a vibrant and historically rooted entrepreneurial ecosystem shaped by local commercial traditions, diversified enterprise activities, and active small-scale business participation. The overall findings suggest that the municipality continues to function as an important local entrepreneurial centre with strong dependence on internal market networks and community-based business culture.

The descriptive analysis showed that entrepreneurship in Kunnamkulam is dominated by manufacturing, service, and trading sectors, while most enterprises operate with comparatively low levels of capital investment. A significant share of businesses depends mainly on markets within Kunnamkulam itself, indicating the importance of local economic circulation in sustaining enterprises. The study also observed that many enterprises have maintained stable business conditions over recent years, while only a smaller proportion experienced major expansion or decline.

The analysis further indicates that entrepreneurship in Kunnamkulam is socially broad-based, with participation from individuals belonging to different educational backgrounds and social categories. However, entrepreneurial participation remains comparatively higher among men than women. At the same time, women employees were found to be more visible within sectors such as manufacturing, trading, and services.

Financially, the entrepreneurial ecosystem continues to rely heavily on personal and family savings rather than institutional financing. The statistical findings suggest that access to finance and interaction with municipal institutions are among the more influential factors affecting entrepreneurial functioning and business convenience within the municipality.

The inferential analysis also revealed that business practices and modernisation patterns differ across entrepreneurs, particularly across age groups and enterprise sectors. At the same time, certain expected growth-related factors such as technology usage, government scheme participation, turnover level, trade body support, and geographical proximity to nearby commercial centres showed comparatively limited influence on market expansion and business growth within the study context.

Overall, the findings portray Kunnamkulam as a culturally mature but institutionally transitioning entrepreneurial municipality where traditional business systems continue to coexist with gradual processes of modernisation and governance engagement. The study suggests that strengthening institutional support, improving financial inclusion, increasing awareness of government support mechanisms, encouraging women participation, and promoting broader market connectivity can further enhance the sustainability and competitiveness of Kunnamkulam's entrepreneurial ecosystem.